

⚡ RAPID DOWNLOAD #5: EFFECTS

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Read this the first time the MC asks a player to choose Effects for their action:

When we want to play through a conflict in detail or find out exactly how effective an action was, I will ask you to choose Effects for your action – as long as you didn't get a miss. This is called a **tracked outcome**.

When you choose Effects, you **spend the Power of your action** to give or remove statuses and story tags, gain new information, or perform extra feats. You may spend 1 additional Power if you rolled a strong hit and chose to take Consequences for a greater effect.

Let's review the Effects you can choose from:

Hand out the Effects sheet or cards so that players can review them.

When acting against an opponent or a target, you can **Attack**, giving them a harmful status, **Disrupt**, giving them a hindering status, **Influence**, giving them a compelling status, or **Weaken**, taking away their useful statuses and tags.

When acting to benefit yourself or an ally, you can **Bestow** new abilities using story tags, **Create** new objects or beings with story tags, **Enhance** yourself or an ally with helpful statuses, or **Restore** yourself or an ally by removing negative statuses and tags.

Discover lets you gain new information, while **Extra Feat** lets you embellish your action with small advantages or secondary achievements.

(We'll learn about **Advance** and **Set Back** later, when we need them.)

The most important rule here is that your Effects must reasonably match your narration. You can't narrate hurting someone and then try to **Restore** them. Usually this should be straight forward, but if you're not sure, I will help you choose.

Let's try it: you have (**say the number**) Power to spend on this action's Effects. What Effects do you choose?

If the player chooses an Effect that involves statuses, continue to **Rapid Download #7: Statuses** (page 103). If a player chooses an Effect that involves story tags, continue to **Rapid Download #8: Story Tags & Tag Effects** (page 110).

EFFECTS

AGAINST AN OPPONENT OR A TARGET

ATTACK

Slash, punch, shoot, zap

Give your target a harmful status

1 POWER PER TIER

DISRUPT

Blind, confuse, shock, trip, jam, interrupt

Give your target a hindering tag or status

1 POWER PER TIER

2 POWER PER TAG

INFLUENCE

Convince, threaten, provoke, hack, mind-control

Give your target a compelling status

1 POWER PER TIER

WEAKEN

Break, sunder, defuse, neutralize, nullify, silence

Remove a target's useful tag or status

1 POWER PER TIER

2 POWER PER TAG

FOR YOURSELF OR FOR AN ALLY

BESTOW

Teach, learn, impart, empower, enchant, equip

Give yourself or an ally new abilities using tags

2 POWER PER TAG

CREATE

Craft, find, purchase, loot, summon, build, rally

Create a new object or being using tags

2 POWER PER TAG

ENHANCE

Assist, aim, boost, energize, take cover, gain advantage

Give yourself or an ally a helpful status

1 POWER PER TIER

RESTORE

Heal, repair, rejuvenate, regain, alleviate, undo

Reduce a harmful status or recover a burnt power tag

1 POWER PER TIER

2 POWER PER TAG

ON A PROCESS

ADVANCE

Make progress, get closer, push forward

Increase a progress status

1 POWER PER TIER

SET BACK

Delay, ruin, sabotage, reverse

Decrease a progress status

1 POWER PER TIER

OTHER EFFECTS

DISCOVER

Sense, recall information, research, converse, reveal

Discover a valuable detail

1 POWER PER DETAIL

EXTRA FEAT

1 Power per additional feature or minor achievement included in the action

Some actions beg an answer to the question of **how well the action succeeded**. When the MC wants to track a Challenge in greater detail, she may ask the player to choose Effects. Or, if the player wants to receive specific game benefits from their action, such as gain a beneficial status, they may opt to choose Effects for their actions.

A player must roll a hit on their action – strong (10+) or mixed (7-9) – to be able to choose Effects. If the player rolled a strong hit they can choose to take Consequences for a greater success and increase their Power by 1 before spending it.

UNDER THE HOOD

The Effects in the Effects list are organized as common action types to help players envision what actions their PCs can take in the game. In game terms, however, there are only three **core Effects**, which can be used to represent any action:

- Adding or removing a status tier (1 Power)
- Adding or removing a story tag (2 Power) (This also applies to burning or recovering a power tag)
- Gaining a valuable detail (1 Power)

Performing an extra feat (1 Power) is an **auxiliary Effect** that can only be attached to one of the other Effects.

The player spends their Power on one or more of the following Effects. If the action's Power is zero or less, the player may still spend 1 Power (this is known as the **Rule of Minimum One**). If they get a strong hit and choose a greater success, the player may spend 2 Power – one as the minimum for a hit, and another one for accepting Consequences.

The Effects chosen for an action must match the narrative of the action. The player cannot choose Effects that don't narratively match their action. E.g., they cannot narrate their PC shooting their target and then use **Restore** to heal someone.

Most Effects revolve around adding and removing statuses (conditions) or story tags (things) to your own PC and their allies, to their targets, or to processes that are ongoing in the scene, like a ticking time bomb or a chase; see **Tracked Outcomes**, page 93.

By default, every Effect affects one target. Where size matters, that target is assumed to be human-sized. For an Effect to affect more than that – for example, an explosion that hits many targets or a blessing that affects your entire crew – the entire action needs to be Scaled. Read more about **Scale** on page 118.



TRACKED OUTCOMES

As part of her cinematic considerations, the MC can deem certain goals and achievements in the game as harder to reach or as deserving more airtime and attention than a single roll (quick outcome).

A **tracked outcome** uses **statuses** to see how close it is to being achieved. Every such outcome is given a **Limit** and is only achieved if and when you **stack enough status tiers** to reach that Limit. A Limit is marked by a red highlight.

- To **destroy** an armored bipedal tank, you must **damage** it enough by shooting at it or setting a trap with explosives (**blown-up**).
- To **complete** the ritual, you must continuously **chant** for a certain period of time while keeping the sigils of the pentagram unscathed.
- To **catch** up to the smuggler, you need to close the **distance** between you by piloting your vehicle closer.
- To **turn** a corporate assassin to your side, you must **convince** them to help you by making good arguments or using a hypnotic Source.

Actions that aim to complete or impede a tracked outcome must use an Effect that generates statuses, in order to determine by how much the action furthered or hindered the goal. This measures how much the action added or removed from the track and whether it reached its Limit.

THE DISCOVER EFFECT

When a PC takes action to get more information, it can be resolved using a **quick outcome**: on a hit, the MC shares pertinent information with the player as she sees fit.

Player: I scan the node I just connected to. I'm looking for counter-intrusion processes first. I rolled a 12, a strong hit!

MC: Your scanning software alerts you to two hidden processes running nearby: the floor has some plates that will raise the security level if you touch them, and there is a hatch in the wall that will unleash something big if that happens.

However, if you want to put an emphasis on investigation in your game or if you want to gamify revealing information in your game, use the **Discover** Effect, which allows you to determine how much information a PC uncovered with their action.

SHOULD I MAKE A TAG OR A STATUS?

Story tags are things, beings, and qualities.

- When your PC creates, obtains, or recruits something or someone new: **sword**, **bodyguard**, **gyrocycle**
- When your PC grants themselves or others new abilities: **flight**, **nightvision**, **fire resistance**.
- When your PC creates new things that hinder your opponent: **rough terrain**, **murder of crows**, **patch of oil**
- When your PC inflicts a new type of weakness upon an opponent: **vulnerable to light**

Statuses are transient conditions.

- When your PC tries to harm someone: **wounded**, **restrained**, **cursed**, **humiliated**
- When your PC tries to influence or control someone: **hypnotized**, **charmed**, **convinced**
- When your PC tries to boost someone: **confident**, **solvent**, **magically-charged**
- When your PC tries to weaken someone: **blinded**, **distracted**, **depowered**, **lost**
- When tracking progress: **on-my-way**, **performing-ritual**, **undergoing-transformation**

Sometimes you can use either, when the desired effect can be interpreted as a thing or a state. For example, you can create **cover** as a tag (and then others can use it later) or **behind-cover** as a status (and then it can have tiers which helps when you mitigate). If the focus is on the thing that is created, use a story tag; if it's on the condition that arises from the thing, use a status.

In game terms, statuses can give a lot of Power to your actions, but only the best and worst statuses apply to any single roll. Story tags on the other hand have the advantages of always affecting an action's Power when they are relevant, but each only provides one point of Power; in order to gain more Power from tags you have to describe your creation with more detail, which may or may not apply to your action.

The most important use of statuses is maxing out Limits. To overcome Challenges, you *must* use a status. Story tags can help, but they can't defeat a Challenge.

For each point of Power spent on **Discover**, the MC gives the PC one detail that can help them achieve their goals or get a better understanding of their environment, or the player can ask one question and the MC provides a valuable answer or a valuable clue that could lead to the answer.

Some MCs may even allow the player to come up with the detail that their character has discovered, one per point of Power, but these should indeed be details (“the killer was 8 feet tall”), and not new items or things in the scene, since these could amount to new story tags and therefore should be added as a **Create** Effect.

Player: I scan the node I just connected to. I’m looking for counter-intrusion processes, using my *scanning app* and *careful approach*. I rolled a 12, a strong hit! I have a Power of 2 so I can ask two questions. First, *what are the threats here?*

MC: Your scanning software alerts you to two hidden processes running nearby: the floor has some plates that will raise the security level if you touch them, and there is a hatch in the wall that will unleash something big if that happens.

Player: Okay, question number two: *what will it unleash?*

MC: It’s hard to tell just by looking at its code, but it’s some kind of a dinosaur-shaped guardian bot.

The information provided with **Discover** should be relevant to the player’s action and the tags used in it. A player cannot use tech to scan for weapon upgrades and then use **Discover** to ask about an NPC’s feelings.

For more guides and instructions about running an investigative game, see the *City of Mist MC Toolkit* book.

THE EXTRA FEAT EFFECT

The **Extra Feat** Effect can be used by the player to add small beneficial narrative developments that are not measured by tags and statuses. Every successful roll by default allows the player to narrate the success of their action and choose Effects; Extra Feats allows the player to add additional secondary goals to that success, beyond their originally declared intention. Therefore, this Effect can only be chosen after the player spent at least 1 Power on other Effects.

It’s up to the MC’s judgment if something can be done as an **Extra Feat** or whether it warrants its own separate action. The best **Extra Feats** are those that flow naturally out of the action that was rolled and keep things going,

while also don’t seem to be worthy of enough attention to be turned into statuses or tags.

An **Extra Feat** is not a separate action but an integral part of the main action. As such, it must be reasonable within the description of the main action. For example, a PC cannot aggressively threaten a street gang, and then use an **Extra Feat** to go unnoticed.

Extra Feats can include:

- **Getting an extra benefit from the main action** (buying oneself extra time or getting an extra favor from a contact).
- **Embellishing or enhancing the main action** (performing it without anyone noticing, preventing it from causing collateral damage, or quickly reloading a gun after shooting).
- **Performing the main action exceptionally quickly**, opening up the possibility of an extended spotlight (see **Keeping the Spotlight**, page 82). The MC may require the use of this **Extra Feat** to allow a follow-up action within the same spotlight.
- **Reaching a coveted position** in the scene (such as in a battlefield or on a stage).
- **Protecting oneself or another person from an incoming Threat** in a way that doesn’t use tags or statuses, preventing it from happening similarly to how a quick outcome would (ducking or pushing someone behind solid cover before someone opens fire, or jacking out before a program traces you).
- **Blocking an opponent** from reaching a coveted position in the scene (preventing access to a Source) or from taking a specific action (taunting them so they don’t attack anyone else). The MC can decide that reaching a position should be measured with a Limit, or that forcing a certain behavior requires a **Disrupt** or **Influence** Effect.
- **Grabbing something accessible** in a way that would not entail a struggle (snatching a Source set on a nearby pedestal or drugs in an unlocked cabinet). The MC can decide the item becomes a story tag. If a struggle is required, the PC must take a separate action to obtain the item. If the player wants a tag for the item or the MC wants to measure how *much* they obtained, use the **Create** Effect instead.

HELPING AND ACTING TOGETHER

When a PC wants to **help another PC take a specific action**, they may use one of two ways (but not both):

- When the active PC is counting their Power for the action, each helping PC may invoke one of their tags to help, providing +1 Power per helpful tag as normal. As with other tags, the MC is the final arbitrator on whether or not such tags are relevant and truly enables the helping PC to enhance the active PC's action in the given circumstances. Helping tags cannot be burned for power (page 122). The MC may rule that the helping PC's negative tags or statuses prevent or hinder such assistance.
- A helping PC can take preparatory action to assist the active PC. They must take the spotlight before the active PC acts, take an action to help the active PC, and spend their Power on Effects that give the active PC helpful tags and statuses using **Bestow**, **Create**, and **Enhance**.

A helping PC often becomes involved in the final action and may suffer its Consequences along with the active PC.

When the PCs are all engaging in the same activity, with no one leading in particular, the MC may ask the crew to **act together**. This applies mostly for actions taken over a period of time, such as traversing the jungle or laying low to avoid a government agency from finding the crew. Suspenseful actions, such as the crew sneaking past a meditating high techno-priest, should be checked individually. When acting together, each crew member invokes a single positive tag that must represent their significant contribution to the joint effort. The MC determines which weakness tags and statuses apply to the entire action, if any. Since the whole crew is engaging in the same action, consider it as being carried out by a Scale 1 entity.

OPTIONAL RULE: HIGHER COST TO ENHANCE

By default, players can use the **Enhance** Effect to grant themselves or a fellow crew member significant positive statuses at the cost of 1 Power per tier. This can lead to exciting build-up and creative team-ups, but it can also make the game easier for the players.

If the players in your group often make use of **Enhance** to build up a lot of Power and you'd like to challenge them more, you may decide that the Enhance Effect costs 2 Power per status tier. There are also many other ways to increase the difficulty level of the game, see **Making The Game Harder** (page 126).

SUMMARY: TAKING AN ACTION

When a player has the spotlight, they can take an action as their PC in the following way:

1. NARRATE the action.

2. ROLL+POWER: The MC will ask you to roll if and when your action is uncertain and dramatic. Count the action's **Power**:

- Gain one point of Power for every positive tag
- Lose one point of Power for every negative tag
- Add the tier of the highest positive status
- Subtract the tier of the highest negative status

Roll two six-sided dice, adding the result to your Power. Compare your total to the outcome categories:

- **10+: A strong hit.** You succeed. You may take Complications for a greater success.
- **7-9: A mixed hit.** You succeed but the MC will deal Consequences.
- **6-: A miss.** The MC will deal Consequences.

3. EFFECT: If the degree of success matters, the MC will ask you to choose Effects for this action. Spend your Power on Effects that best reflect your action:

- Against an Opponent or a Target
 - » **Attack:** Give your target a harmful status (1 per tier)
 - » **Influence:** Give your target a compelling status (1 per tier)
 - » **Disrupt:** Give your target a negative tag or status (1 per tier or 2 per tag)
 - » **Weaken:** Remove an target's useful tag or status (1 per tier or 2 per tag)
- For Yourself or for an Ally
 - » **Bestow:** Give yourself or an ally a new ability tag (2 per tag)
 - » **Create:** Create a new object or being using tags (2 per tag)
 - » **Enhance:** Give yourself or an ally a helpful status (1 per tier)
 - » **Restore:** Reduce a harmful status or recover a burnt power tag (1 per tier or 2 per tag)
- On a Process
 - » **Advance:** Increase a progress status (1 per tier)
 - » **Set Back:** Decrease a progress status (1 per tier)
- Other Effects
 - » **Discover:** Discover a valuable detail (1 per detail)
 - » **Extra Feat** (1 per extra feat)

FOR THE MC: QUICK VS. TRACKED CONFLICTS

In a movie, the screenwriters determine whether a conflict is resolved quickly or take a large chunk of the scene. In *:Otherscape*, the MC chooses whether a conflict between a PC and a Challenge should be resolved in a single action or in a series of actions.

- A **quick conflict** is completed in one action, no matter how long it takes the PC to complete that action. It's concise, so as not to take up too much of the airtime in the conversation.

- A **tracked conflict** can take many actions to complete, no matter how short each action is within the narrative. It's often the main focal point of the scene, a conflict we want to watch play-by-play or blow-by-blow.

Any conflict can be resolved either way. While in most media combat is traditionally resolved in long form and boosting a car, for example, is often resolved in short form, sometimes it's the other way around – depending on what the director and writers feel would be more tense and appropriate to the genre. It's the same in *:Otherscape*.

An experienced MC is cognizant of what to put in focus by resolving it in long form and what to resolve quickly in short form in order to move the story along, depending on her cinematic considerations in the series, session, and specific scene.

	QUICK [SHORT FORM]	TRACKED [LONG FORM]
Brutal alleyway gunfight	The PC walks into the alleyway, but the camera doesn't follow them. We hear gunshots and screams. Fade to the PC with a gun wound in their shoulder standing over the dead bodies of their enemies.	An involved fight scene, where every shot, every dash for cover, every spell unleashed gets its own dramatic beat. The scene does not end until every last combatant is downed, or flees.
Convincing a bartender to talk	A long shot of the PC chatting with the bartender. We don't know what exactly is being said. The PC comes away with a smile – they got the info.	A close up of the PC and the bartender. Every word and expression is loaded with meaning, and we can see the bartender going back and forth with what they're willing to share, while also trying to glean information from the PC.
A ritual to summon a demon	A quick montage of the PC preparing for the ritual, lighting the candle, and chanting the incantation before the demon suddenly appears in a cloud of red smoke.	An entire scene where the PC contends with cosmic laws, employing invocations and making sacrifices to stave off otherworldly protections. Someone or something attempts to sabotage the ritual, forcing the PC to go to greater lengths to complete it.
A hacking session to locate a hidden file	"Let me get that file for you," the hacker says and slides into cyberspace, although we don't see what happens there. A few beads of sweat and painful grimaces later he jacks out, panting, "phew... okay, I got it."	"Let me get that file for you," the hacker says and slides into cyberspace. Inside, he patches into a server that looks like a medieval Japanese castle. Loading up his ninja anti-detection code, we watch him as he creeps from room to room, searching for the file, taking out samurai-shaped counter-intrusion processes, until finally he finds the scroll-shaped file and jacks out in the last nanosecond, saying, "phew... okay, I got it."

CHALLENGE PROFILES

Some Challenges, especially ones that are designed to be overcome with a single action and without going into game Effects (quick outcome) are described only by a handful of tags, Threats, and Consequences. In published materials, these appear as part of the description of the Challenge when it's introduced in the text.

For example, a wanted hacker could be simply described as being **barricaded-2** behind a heavy door and **scared-3**, or a Zarathustran fire-breather could emit **intense heat** and have the ability to incinerate the Source the crew is after (**Deny Them Something They Want**) or burn their opponents (a cone-shaped stream of fire that causes **burned-3**).

More involved Challenges – such as a formidable opponent, an escalating situation, or an environment full of dangers – which are designed to be handled as tracked outcomes, with Limits that must be maxed out, are described by a Challenge Profile.

A Challenge Profile lists the following elements of a Challenge:

- **Limits:** What kinds of statuses could overcome this Challenge and at what tier. Progress Limits are also placed here with Specials that trigger when the Limit is maxed out, marked with .
- **Base Tags:** The tags this Challenge has by default.
- **Specials:** Unique rules that trigger whenever their conditions apply. These abilities make the Challenge into a unique problem for the PCs.
- **Threat and Consequences:** A list of Threats this Challenge can pose during the Establish phase and related Consequences that can be delivered when these Threats are not addressed. Some Threats are standalone and could result in many different kinds of Consequences. Some Consequences are standalone and usually represent likely reactions, such as a counterattack. All of these are suggestions; the MC can use any Threats or Consequences as they please, alter them, or add new ones on the fly.



NITRO GANG MEMBER

In districts the police ignore and the corporations write off, gangs run the streets. This Challenge represents the street-level thugs who never leave home without a weapon at their side and a “pick-me-up” in their pocket. By themselves, they’re a minor threat. But once they get hyped up on drugs – or even worse, magic – all bets are off.

— LIMITS

HURT OR SUBDUE **3**

THREATEN **4**

— TAGS & STATUSES

home field advantage

— SPECIALS

Let's Go Nitro! Once per scene, during Establish, the Gang Member injects themselves with a performance-enhancing street drug, gaining **nitro-reflexes-2**. When this status expires, replace it with **hungover-3**.

— THREATS / » CONSEQUENCES

- » *Emerge from an alley with a weapon already in hand*
 - » **Snatch something out of someone's hands** (**burn a tag describing a possession**)
 - » **Spit out a threat** (**intimidated-2**)
 - » **Beat with an improvised melee weapon** (**bruised-2**) or **fire a stolen pistol** (**flesh-wound-2**)
- » *Warn that their “friends” will be here soon*
 - » **Instant message her buddies** (**increase Scale by 1**)

Find more ready-to-use Challenge Profiles under the **Challenge Database** (page 301) or create your own using the guide **Creating Challenges** (page 294).